

ART283 History of Animation *The Illusion of Life*

Semester: Fall 2026

Location: Alumni Hall, Room 302

Days/Times: M/W/F 8:00–8:50am

Instructor: Mark Baldridge

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Student Hours: Fridays 9am to Noon —other times by appointment

Office: 345 Science Hall

PRO-TIP: *When emailing any professor about a course, begin the "Subject" line with the course number or name -then clearly state your reason for writing*

Introduction

From the catalog:

The history of animation is the history of image making and performance — of photography, cinema, sound, computers and AI

Within this context we'll explore:

- **Technologies**

From cave painting to photography to motion pictures to animation, to computer simulation, each is based on a certain level of technology and until the technology exists, certain kinds of artifacts are difficult to imagine and may be impossible to execute

The history of animation is a history of certain technologies

- **Techniques**

Drawing every frame can be grueling and expensive, "cell" style and "limited" animation cut out some of the expense and labor, what this means for the quality of animation in an open question

Techniques vary a great deal over time and artists may invent their own. Technique is in the manner of using the technologies at hand

- **People**

Certain individuals and groups are inextricably linked with the history of animation, whether as artists, innovators producers of project or "talent", the leave an indelible mark on the animation of their time and whatever follows

People bring personality to the history of animation, whether they are colorful individuals who stand out, or quiet innovators behind the scenes

Goals and Objectives

Instructional Goals:

- Learn how animation developed, grew and consider where it's going
- Explore the relation people and technologies, which brings about technique
- Develop ideas, theses and learn to express them in a cogent manner
- Imagine the future of animation

Learning Objectives

- **Knowledge** Become conversant with the history of animation, know the names, the techniques and the tech that makes it possible
 - **Conceptual** Become able to identify themes, similarities, difference between artists, styles, eras animation
 - **Developmental** Learn to express your informed thoughts on the subject of animation and its past, develop critical apparatus for discussing the challenges and merits of animated works
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Organization

Portfolio

You will never email or give me your assignment (unless asked, for purposes of critique) but will keep and preserve your work in a digital portfolio.

You may use a google drive — for video files, a youtube channel. Tho if you prefer ftp and Vimeo or some other combo, this is up to you!

I don't wish you to preserve your work in any space tied to your student email. I want you to have access to this material long after graduation, and indeed until you decide to archive or delete it!

If a Google Drive folder, your instructor will want it to be shared by a particular, preferred method:

LINK: [How to share a Google Drive folder with your instructor](#)

You are required to follow this tutorial if using Google Drive!

This kind of digital portfolio is only a few steps away from a professional version, useful for applying for gigs, gradschool or etc.

Your professor will always be eager and ready to help you develop a *professional* portfolio!

Projects

In this course we will produce three Projects

These may be creative, analytical, or expository/critical, or advanced that is:

- **Creative** might include making an animation of your own; writing a screenplay for one; composing and recording "cartoon music"
- **Analysis** could take the shape of a video, comparing the styles of different directors of animation or the work of one director for several studios; demonstrating how a particular technology works, writing an essay on the life and or works of a person important to the history of animation
- **Exposition** includes offering factual accounts or explanations, criticism compares and judges; one might expound on how sync sound changed

animation or critique an animation or animation studio

- **Advanced** Consider taking your projects to a new level, something publishable, competitive or prize-worthy. Advanced projects must be submitted to some external contest, publisher or festival

Evaluation

All course work will be evaluated on the basis of a 100-point semester

- **Casual Assignments**
 - Each of these is calculated to lead to a particular Project
 - The number of these may vary, but for each of the three sections, assignments will always total 10 points (if there are five Casual Assignments leading up to *Project One*, each will be worth 2 points, etc)
(May include quizzes, rapid fire discussion prompts, simple written responses)
- **Three Projects**
 - As described and named above
 - Each worth a maximum of 20 points
- **The remaining 10 points are divided into:**
 - *Creativity Points* (3)
 - Show design-centric work which engages viewers on an aesthetic level
 - *Innovation Points* (3)
 - Demonstrate techniques or approaches not covered in class, seek to educate yourself beyond the coursework and demonstrate that knowledge
 - *Engagement Points* (4)
 - Show up to and engage in classroom conversations, ask and answer questions, *help your peers* (this last is always the most impressive to your instructor)

Examples:

Let's take our Project One

The project is worth a maximum of 20 points

As a means of exploration and skill building, and in preparation for the Project, a set of Casual Assignments will prepare us for this project

Casual assignments for this section, whatever their number, will be worth 10 points, total

Casual Assignments which are not quizzes may be evaluated by *completion*: to perform them *as described* earns full points

Projects must be completed to a higher standard and demand a learner's best efforts in design thinking, execution and expressiveness

A close reading of the above reveals that three Projects and all supporting tutorial assignments are worth only a total of 90 points—a further 10 points are available through three channels: The remaining 10 points are divided into:

• **3 Creativity points** • **3 Innovation points** • **4 Engagement points**

Which accrue throughout the semester

If, early on, you have only one Creativity point, for example, be aware that this grade will not be complete until the semester ends!

Details of Scale

My evaluation scale looks like this:

A grades	B grades	C grades
A+ : 98-100	B+ : 88-90	C+ : 78-80
A : 94-97	B : 84-87	C : 74-77
A- : 91-93	B- : 81-83	C- : 71-73

As this may not be a scale you've seen before, it's worth noting that:

The range of A- begins at 91 points

B- begins at 81

C- at 71

There are no gradations of the D eval, but the range is 60-70

I'm Happy to discuss my grading system, or any particular grade!

Tracking Grades

Grades will be posted after each Project comes to completion but it's the grades (midterm and final) posted on Self Service which are considered the student's official grades

Calendar Fall 2026

WEEK	GOAL	NOTE
1. 08/24		Friday 28, last day to add or change a course
2. 08/31	Project One assigned	
3. 09/07		
4. 09/14		Friday 18, Quality/Non election ends
5. 09/21	Project One due	
6. 09/28		
7. 10/05	Project Two Assigned	MIDTERMS
8. 10/12		FALL BREAK (Monday, Tuesday)
9. 10/19		GAME JAM opens Sunday / Wednesday, Midterm grades due
10. 10/26	Project two Due	GAME JAM due at 12pm Monday 26, Awards tuesday at 7pm, Tav Shande Judges / Spring registration begins
11. 11/02		
12. 11/09		
13. 11/16	Project Three assigned	Monday 16, Last day to withdraw with W

WEEK	GOAL	NOTE
14. 11/23		Wednesday 25 THANKSGIVING BREAK
15. 11/30		Friday 4, LAST CLASS
16. 12/07	Project Three due	FINALS WEEK

Later Dates

Last Incomplete request: Dec 14 FINAL GRADES DUE: Dec 16 Last Q/Non@
 Reversal: Jan 8 Last day to resolve "Incomplete": Feb. 9
